

ShareToNeighbour — Beginner-Friendly User Guide (Local Setup)

This guide explains how to run **ShareToNeighbour** on a local computer using **XAMPP** and how to use the main features: registration, posting items, requesting items, chatting, reviews, and the support chatbot.

1. Before You Start

To follow this guide, you should have:

- A Windows laptop or PC (recommended for XAMPP)
- XAMPP installed with Apache and MySQL
- A web browser such as Chrome, Edge, or Firefox
- An optional real email address if you want to receive password reset and notification emails

2. Start XAMPP Services

- Open the XAMPP Control Panel.
- Click Start next to:
 - Apache
 - MySQL

When both indicators turn green, the local server is ready.

3. Place the Project in the Correct Folder

- Find the XAMPP `htdocs` folder, usually located at `C:\xampp\htdocs\`.
- Copy the project folder into `htdocs` so the final path becomes:
 - `C:\xampp\htdocs\ShareToNeighbour\`

The project can then be accessed at:

- `http://localhost/ShareToNeighbour/`

4. Create and Import the Database

4.1 Open phpMyAdmin

Open the following address in a browser:

- `http://localhost/phpmyadmin`

4.2 Import the SQL File

- Open the **Import** tab.
- Click **Choose File** and select the project's `.sql` file, commonly located in a `database/` or `sql/` folder.
- Click **Go** to start the import.

After the import is complete, the database tables should appear in phpMyAdmin.

If the SQL file cannot be found, search the project folder for files ending in `.sql`.

5. Open the ShareToNeighbour Website

Try one of the following URLs in the browser:

- If the project uses a `public` folder:
 - `http://localhost/ShareToNeighbour/public/`
- Otherwise:
 - `http://localhost/ShareToNeighbour/`

The ShareToNeighbour homepage should now appear.

6. Create an Account

- Click **Join Community** or **Register**.
- Enter a name, email address, and password.

Using a real email address is recommended if the platform is expected to send:

- Password reset links
- Notification or alert emails

If SMTP is not configured on the computer, the platform may still work, but emails will not be delivered.

7. Browse Furniture Near You

- Click **Browse Furniture** from the menu.
- View furniture listings near the saved address.
- Open any listing to see its details and photos.

8. Post a Furniture Listing (Owner)

Make sure you are logged in before posting a listing.

Listing rules:

- **Title:** at least 3 characters
- **Description:** at least 10 characters
- **Category:** sofa, table, chair, bed, shelf, desk, wardrobe, or other
- **Condition:** like_new, good, fair, or needs_repair

Photo rules:

- Minimum 1 and maximum 3 photos
- Allowed formats: JPG, PNG, GIF, WEBP
- Maximum size: 5 MB per photo
- The first photo becomes the cover photo

After submission, the listing becomes available to other users.

9. Request an Item (Requester)

- Open a listing of interest.
- Click the Request button.
- The listing status changes to requested.
- The owner can review and accept one request.

10. Complete an Exchange and Mark the Item as Taken (Owner)

After the item has been picked up or handed over:

- The owner logs in and marks the item as **taken**.

Notes:

- Items marked as taken are no longer available for further requests.
- The records remain in the system for admin audit and to preserve transaction and review history.

11. Leave a Review

A review can be left only after:

- The request has been accepted
- The item has been marked as taken by the owner

Review rules:

- **Rating:** 1 to 5 stars

- **Comment:** optional, up to around 500 characters
- **Photo:** optional, following the same image rules as listing photos
- One review per transaction per reviewer

12. Real-Time Chat / Messaging

Some versions of ShareToNeighbour include a small chat server for real-time messaging. If messages do not appear instantly, the chat server may need to be started manually.

- Open **Terminal** or **Command Prompt** in the project folder, for example:

```
cd C:\xampp\htdocs\ShareToNeighbour
```

- Run the PHP WebSocket server:

```
php C:\xampp\htdocs\shareToNeighbour\ws-server.php
```

- Keep the terminal window open while testing chat.

To test chat with two users:

- Open Chrome and Edge, or use two different browsers
- Log in as **User 1** in one browser
- Log in as **User 2** in the other browser
- Send messages and confirm they appear without manually refreshing the page

13. Use the Support Chatbot

- Open the chatbot widget, usually located in the bottom corner of the page.
- Type a question or issue.
- Click **Send** or press **Enter**.

If a **backend error** appears:

- The chatbot backend, often an Ollama model, may be slow or may time out when using heavier models.

The following command can be used in Terminal:

```
ollama serve
```

14. Open the Site on a Phone (Same Wi-Fi)

14.1 Find the PC IP Address

On the Windows PC:

- Open Command Prompt.
- Run:

```
ipconfig
```

- Look for the IPv4 Address, for example 192.168.1.10.

14.2 Open the Site on the Phone

In the phone browser, enter:

- `http://192.168.1.10/ShareToNeighbour/public/`

Replace the sample IP address with the actual IPv4 address of the computer.

Make sure that:

- Apache is running in XAMPP
- The PC and phone are connected to the same Wi-Fi network
- The firewall is not blocking access

Quick Start Checklist

- Start Apache and MySQL in XAMPP
- Import the `sharetoneighbou.sql` file in phpMyAdmin
- Open the site in the browser
- Register and log in
- Select the address from the suggestions
- Post, request, accept, mark as taken, and review
- Optionally start the chat server for real-time messaging